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Artist Talk: Finding the Isobue: From the Hydrophone to the Radio studio to the Gallery; spatial sonic designs of an endangered sound

Abstract

Finding the Isobue is the journey I made with the Japanese Environmental activist, Dr Kumi Kato to the remote island of Sugashima in Japan in search of the endangered sound the isobue, the Japanese sea whistle. This sound is made by the Ama women who free dive for abalone and sea creatures maintaining a sustainable fishing practice they have preserved since the time of The Pillow Book. This paper articulates how this significant sound has been interpreted into a number of spatial sound works from original field recordings, radiophonic art, bi-lingual sonic haiku, electroacoustic music for piano, koto, flute, sound sculptures with soundscape and the electronic art 5.1 surround sound installation , a quiet space for contemplation of a disappearing world. The double CD Isobue celebrates the significance of this sound and is dedicated to the Ama.

Introduction

I met Kumi Kato in Canberra while working at the National Museum on sounddesign of public spaces. She mentioned finding a hydrophone to capture the water environment of the Ama's sea whistle sound. In two weeks we were there together in search of the sound and loaded with 40 kilos of sound equipment, 2 DATs, hydrophone, stereo air microphones and backup minidisk. Living in the village of Sugashima, we shared the lives of the fisherfolk women and my main aim was to help Kumi, record the information she needed for research. Listening deeply to the rural Japanese and spending time in the coastal regions was an immersive window of listening. I wrote haiku everyday, like a diary. Together we recorded some 10 CDs of site specific recordings, festivals, Japanese stories, songs, dances and rituals which surround the act of monitored fishing, a system of ritual connection they have maintained for centuries.

When I returned home I realised the cultural value and creative potential of the material we had gathered. An ABC Composers residency with ABC Radio National Sydney, made possible some creative spatial sound designs, a radiophonic story for Radio Eye, *Waiting for the Tide*, a suite of traditional music with soundscape, *Sea-Folk Voices*, the 8 electro-acoustic sonic haiku, *Shima*, the short electroacoustic Vignette, *Ama no Isobue* and the substantial 5.1 installation *Isonageki, Sea Lament*.

Trapping the Sound

How to trap the Isobue when it is made under very strict practices deep in the sea? Many of the younger women can not make it? What about the imperialism of the microphone? Kumi and I spent long hours seeking permission and sharing the stories with the blessing of the women at each site before we began. Kumi helped lug the gear on boats, up cliffs, over rocks, into the sea after her careful negotiations. Taking the weight of the metres of hydrophone cable in a deep moving sea to a depth of 10 metres is a job for two. She also swam with the hydrophone in the cold waters.

In a recent article, Recording for Experiential Flexible Sound Installation, 1977-2007 published in the ASRA Journal 2008, no 34, I have noted nine different types of recordings made to effect these different celebrations of an intangible cultural heritage.

On location in Japan these included
* hydrophone underwater and air recordings,
*180 degrees stereo mike into DAT for soundscape environmental recordings, the village night, early morning at the fisheries auction,
*Japanese interviews with key women divers and fishermen,
*90 degrees directional recordings for detailed crabs and sea creatures on the rocks, insects,
*omni-directional dummyhead surround sound stereo recordings on the rock during the women's diving and coming up for air and emitting the whistles in a community sea location.

Creating the Sound Palette

In the ABC studios, I used techniques which would serve my creative imagination for the new works to be made. Anything was possible with Andrei Shabunov's help. I amassed a huge array

of recorded sounds and modules which would aggregate as a sonic palette to design the simulated underwater environment, the world of the women to situate their sound.
*the anechoic chamber was used to carry out many experimental recordings of situational water, whistle simulations and instrumental samples of psaltery, Satsuki's Koto, and recorders and flutes.
*the interior and keys of the slightly out of tune Bosendorfer grand piano in studio 256 was a world of underwater danger as well as a wonderful instrument for live performance of *Aonominesun*.
*Studio Vocal recordings were made of my haiku in Japanese and English as well as translations of Japanese texts to be used for poetic reflection in the Radio story.
*Original samples of my glass and clay sculptures, the Flagong, Lorraines' ceramic bells, wooden and metal percussion, shells, windchimes, wooden buckets, Japanese paper, and strings were also recorded in the Melbourne studios with Richard Girvan and taken up to Sydney as files. Elaborate submixes were made weaving computer effects on ProTools FX and Wavelab. These were overlayed and dovetailed into complex modules with thematic titles, abolone shell, whistle, bucket, rack, deepsea ready for diverse combinations in the haiku, the installation and radiophonic text underlay.

Design Morphologies and Processes

Different sonic architectures and processes are required for different outcomes. Each one was made with a specific aim in mind, a radio story, a poetic bilingual talisman, an instrumental suite, an Immersive forty-three minute sound installation in 5.1. a short summary electro-acoustic trip. For each the sound files and submixes were collated and roughed out in Wavelab to experiment further.In the Radio Eye piece, a text narrative structure in two languages dominated the flow as readings and translations on many themes had to be fitted together. Kumi and Sharon worked this through in consultation with the rest of us while Andrei and I concentrated on the sonic tapestry to hold the words, underpinning them, obscuring them , enlarging them, drowning them. In the Haiku, the text had a different role, the English defining the audio content and Kumi threading the Japanese response through the tiny sonic vignettes made especially for each one. The *Sea Folk Voices* was intended as a musical suite so the soundscape recordings were subservient to the music written and recorded in two pieces, *Sea Folk Voices* and *Husa*, and improvised in two. The piece *To the Sun Goddess* was a straight recorded improvisation between Satsuki Koto and myself on medieval psaltery while Aominesan was a solo piano piece with soundscape providing the atmosphere of the sacred mountain the Ama pray to before they dive.

By far the densest work was *Isonageki,* Sea Lament a 5.1 surround sound mix where all the electroacoustic mixes were designed in a constantly changing polyphonic spatial array ressembling an underwater environment. *Isobue* CD2 track14. This was mixed in Pro Tools in Melbourne with Richard Girvan. Elaborate scores of the interrelationship of parts to the whole were drawn to communicate the movement and morphology of continuity for all the pieces. Detailed naming of all the files and mixes allowed us to float many materials in different configurations and densities, like the ocean, ebbing and flowing over multi-layered on site recordings of Sugashima, Shirongo, Mendonohama and Champagne beaches. Detailed hydrophone recordings of elephant sharks eating pippis recorded in the Melbourne aquarium were melded with polyps from Pope's Eye in Port Phillip Bay and the Japanese waters. *Isobue* CD1, Track 13.

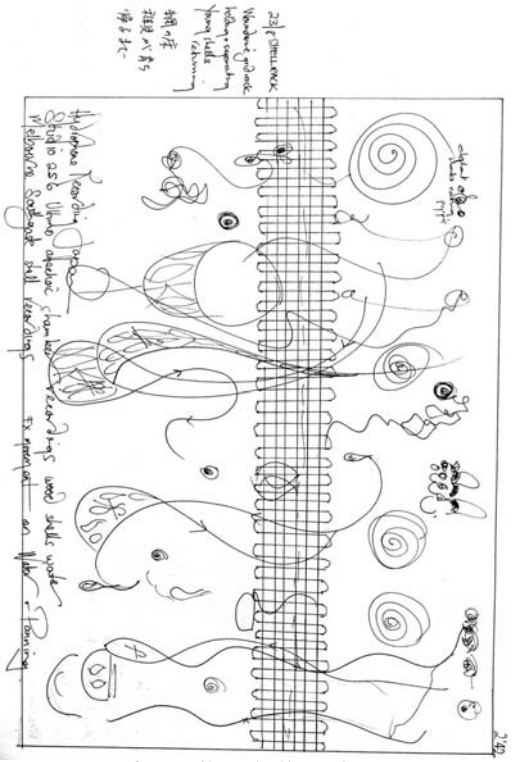


Figure 1.*Score for Haiku Shell Rack*

The electroacoustic soundscape was a global mix to recreate and evoke the Japanese underwater environment where the women risk their lives. The reconstruction of a pseudo natural environment full of beauty, chance and danger is one of the most fulfilling designs I have worked on to date. The spatialisation took days after the initial composition layout and Richard and I worked tirelessly on this intuitively together, carving time as shared experienced human moments and gestures.

Organising the massive shifts and dramaturgy was made possible in a dedicated space especially set up with the speaker array so everything was audited at the moment of creation.

Some of the files and scores for this work appear below.

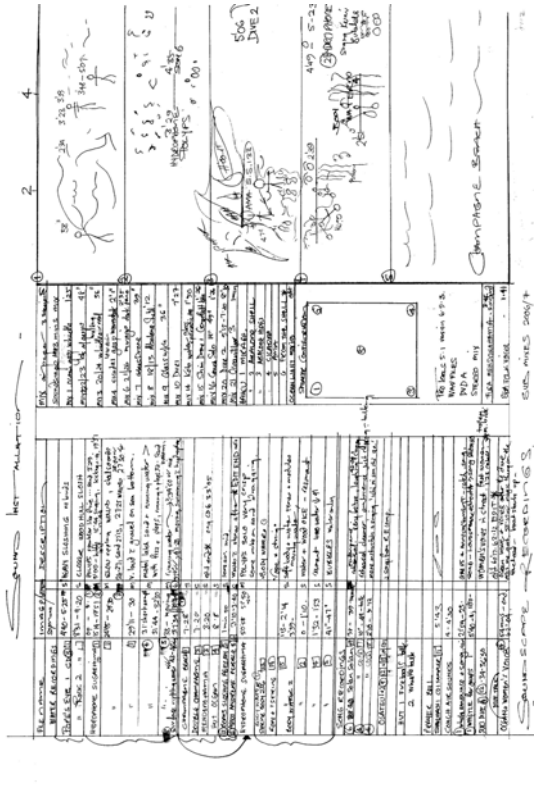


Figure 2. *Installation Score Isonageki, files and map.*

Back in Sydney a the end of the project, Andrei and I made Ama no Isobue, a short summary trip through this long journey, made comprehensible in a few minutes while retaining essential elements of the women and their sea whistle, the sound that orients them in the ocean to the location and eachother, communicates whether their dive was successful in obtaining large abalone or just a sea cucumber, whether they are well, tired, eager for more. It is a sound which is tribally shared and individually uttered containing their life's breath in the face of danger. When there is no text, the meaning is conveyed through the electro-acoustic sound, its density, timbral amelioration and rhythmic unfolding alone.

Spatial Design for Exhibitions

Going into the Gallery with this audio requires visual design and spatial understanding of the acoustic space itself, the flow line of the spectators, the requirements of speakers to wall, floor ceiling surfaces and the general visual and architectural characteristics of the building's size, shape, volume, and surfaces. Every space is an acoustic space and the sensitive positioning of sounds in each discreet space is a skill required of the installation artist.

Sound installation is continuous and open ended. The audience get to define the length of the stay and involvement with the work within the limits of the gallery opening hours. If the environment is friendly with seating or floor coverings encouraging longer stays, it is more likely the work will be better audited. Frequent visits are also an option when works are installed for longer periods such as days and weeks.

The *Shima, 8 Haiku for Kumi* (*Isobue* CD1 8-13) have been exhibited in a group show at the Counihan gallery, Brunswick focusing on embodied energy and sustainable environmental practices curated by Edwina Bartlem and Penny Algar. Headphones were chosen to isolate the listeners' attention from other gallery sounds and framed parallel texts of the eight Haiku, were hung either side of the blue silk falling from the ceiling representing the womens dive. Illuminated shells resting on the rice cooker, reminiscent of the divers wooden bucket, the oke, bring the future domestic allusion to the piece, that the abalone will be sold to eat in the end. Four sets of headphones were chosen at four listening ports under the text, each one containing two haiku on loops. The longest length for each box was between two and three minutes, a good length for standing room only and the brevity of the texts.



Figure 3. *Shima 8 Haiku for Kumi , Counihan Gallery Brunswick, June 6-29, 2008.*

The response has been heartening with four people at once often listening side by side and sharing their thoughts of the listening world.

Designing the 5.1 *Isonageki, Sea lament* is a much different experience. As the theme for the conference is sounds in space it was decided that a simulated underwater environment as an immersive and contemplative surround sound installation would be an appropriate experience for the electroacoustic community. As seasoned listeners they could appreciate the evanescent 43 minute work spatial compsition.. The space needs to be acoustically discreet so the contemplative qualities and sensitive perception of the moving sound masses can be fullysensed. Lighting, 5.1 speaker array with sub woofer and suspension opportunities have been requested. The fifth speaker for the 5.1 should be centrally overhead to articulate the vertical dimension of the sound as movement in a deep sea envi-

ronment. The women's spatial path diving is a mainly vertical one.

Later this year, *Isobue* will be adapted to create a quiet space setting at the University of Queensland for Kumi Kato's Peaceful Space conference in September. The sonic creations will also be taken back to the Ama women in Japan as handwrapped CD gifts. A cassette will be made for their tiny new Ama museum in the small village where technology is not really part of their lives and a simple portable CD player gifted for the repeat play scenario for their artefact display. Headphones or /and speakers will be decided in situe.They are so proud NOT to have technology. It must be kept simple.

In the double CD *Isobue*, the sea whistle as intangible cultural heritage has been celebrated through elaborate digital means and processes, available through large corporations like the ABC, in association with artists, the environmental group ecco and the sonic gallery of the Australia Asia foundation. Part of the proceeds of the disc made on recycled paper will be gifted back to ecco for creative conservation through art projects of this nature. In January the two notated pieces *Sea Folk Voices* and *Husa* will be published in handstitched composer autographed notations and taught at a summer school encouraging recorder players to interpret space notation with electroacoustic soundscape. A new piece *Free Diving* for recorder orchestra, electroacoustic soundscape and graphic notation was premiered in Melbourne in March using extended recorder techniques and the breath in all parts of the disassembled instrument. Through contact with the Isobue, many people are reclaiming the sanctity of life's breath.

In the end it is the quality of the communication between people, the reasons for their lives and the presence of life's breath which is infinitely more important than technology of any kind. Listening and breathing are our first and last experiences in being alive. They validate our presence on earth. The Ama are in tune with the natural environment through listening, and their special sound the Isobue, a rare experience these days. They are immersed in ancient sea culture and are responsive to its every moment. They are *Waiting for the tide.*

Shima: 8 haiku for Kumi is dedicated to Kumi Kato
The double CD *Isobue* is dedicated to the Ama

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Art direction and design of CD: Joseph Griffiths

C Ros Bandt, 2008. Sound Artist,
Japanese soundscape and field recordings, composer, poetry, performer (psaltery, flutes, recorders, Bosendorfer piano, percussion, original glass sculptures, conch, air whistle, shells, glass, clay wood, and brass percussion, voice), Surround sound immersive installation artist.

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